Kejriwal's bond with her own pen pal is still going strong, and after over 20 years of writing to each other, she attended her friend's wedding recently.

If there is one thing that Dubey and Kejriwal have in common, it is that they both found writing as an escape during the loneliness of the Covid-19 pandemic. Dubey started writing letters to herself. "I started practising calligraphy," she says. "It was only me, my worksheets and my nib. It was meditative. Even now, if I feel stressed about anything, I withdraw to my pen because it instantly relieves my stress. I inhale with every upstroke, exhale with every downstroke." Kejriwal, too, found writing as a way to beat the isolation. "It struck me how effective writing was to feel connected to others and yourself," she says.

MORE THAN JUST NOSTALGIA

In fact, you could say, there is a whole movement towards a return to writing, whether for yourself or to others. You can see it in the letter-writing carnivals, workshops and even letter museums that have come up in recent years. Once, there would be long queues in front of 'professional' letter-writers at post offices who helped people who couldn't read or write. Festivals would come bearing handwritten greetings from friends and family; lovers would save letters from their beloved. Keeping a diary or a journal remains a hobby for many even now.

Yet, it is not just nostalgia that is nudging the return to writing. Numerous studies have attested to its therapeutic effects—be it journaling, penning letters or creative writing—for several mental health issues such as depression, anxiety or even ADHD. In the fall of 2018, a sample group of 20 community members and 28 students participated in two rounds of letter exchanges. The results, published in the *Journal of Social Work* in 2021, revealed that writing letters helped participants battle loneliness and establish a sense of social connection. After attending The Daakroom Letter Writing Carnival held by the Union ministry of culture and the department of posts in Delhi last year, 10-year-old Sunaina Rustagi (*name changed*) came home with a number of new friends from different parts of the city. The event saw nearly 10,000 youngsters connect to thousands more in 50 schools across the capital. Sunaina, whose parents are divorced, found the exercise healing. She continues to write letters to stay in touch with the friends she made at the carnival and, according to her mother, is able to voice her emotions about living away from her father. This has helped Sunaina deal with anger, be more open to conversation with her parents and be happier at school. As for the hugely successful Daakroom Carnival itself, there are plans to hold another edition in the capital this year. Says co-founder Shivani Mehta, 31,



JAI RANJIT



FROM A BYGONE ERA

1. Pooja Dubey shows off her calligraphy art

2. Rohini Kejriwal, who runs Chitthi Exchange

3. The Daakroom event in Delhi